

Thailand — Chiang Mai & the North

7 - 12 September 2026

Haris Haikal & Aina Izzaty · one hotel for five nights, day trips out, no driver to arrange
Green season: waterfalls at full flow, terraces vivid green, low season prices.

The Six Days

DAY	DATE	SHAPE	WHERE	DRIVING
Day 1	Mon, 7 Sep	Fly + city	Old City, Nimman cafés	none
Day 2	Tue, 8 Sep	Mountain day	Doi Inthanon	~4h
Day 3	Wed, 9 Sep	Gardens + cafés	Mae Rim, Bua Tong falls	~2h
Day 4	Thu, 10 Sep	Long day out	Chiang Rai temples	~6h
Day 5	Fri, 11 Sep	Temple + markets	Doi Suthep, Warorot	~1h
Day 6	Sat, 12 Sep	Fly home	CNX → KUL	20 min

Book Tonight, In This Order

1 Ask Malaysia Airlines to reroute, don't cancel

MAS runs two of the three daily KUL-Chiang Mai flights (MH772 09:50→11:40, MH792 11:50→13:40). If they cancel CGK, ask to be moved onto their Chiang Mai service instead of refunded.
+60 3-7843-3000

2 Flights KUL → CNX on 7 Sept, and the return on 12 Sept

8 flights a week on the route: MH772, MH792, and AirAsia AK856 (13:30→15:10). 2h 40m.

3 TDAC — Thailand Digital Arrival Card

Mandatory for every entry, filed online at tdac.immigration.go.th before you arrive. The Thai equivalent of the Indonesian e-CD — don't skip it.

4 Hotel — five nights, one place

Old City or Nimman. No hotel switch in this version, so unpack once.

5 Two day tours with car + driver

Doi Inthanon (Day 2) and Chiang Rai (Day 4). Hotel desk, Klook or GetYourGuide. Book both tonight — they leave early.

6 Cancel or move the Bandung bookings

Holiday Inn Pasteur, Swiss-Belresort Dago, Fairfield CGK — ask for a waiver citing the airport closure. Message Kiki.

7 Insurance, eSIM, offline maps

Re-issue the insurance for Thailand and keep the Bandung cancellation paperwork for the claim. Signal is fine in the city, patchy on Doi Inthanon.

Good To Know

Visa

Visa-free for Malaysians — the 60-day exemption still applies on 7 Sept (30 days from 15 Sept, irrelevant for 5 nights).

Weather

Green season: ~33°C, humid, ~18 rainy days in September. Showers come late afternoon or overnight — mornings are the clear window.

Money

Thai baht. Cards fine in the city; cash for markets, temples, park entry.

Temple dress

Shoulders and knees covered at every temple, both of you. A light scarf handles it.

Getting around

Grab and Bolt everywhere; songthaews ~30-40 THB a hop. The two mountain days come with a driver.

Why here

Waterfalls at full flow, terraces at their greenest, and the quietest, cheapest month of the year.

Flight out: _____ Flight home: _____ Booking ref: _____
Doi Inthanon tour: _____ Chiang Rai tour: _____ Checked 6 Sept 2026 — confirm fares and availability.

DAY 1

Fly to Chiang Mai + Old City

Monday, 7 September

START 09.50 from KLIA	FINISH ~21.00	SLEEP Chiang Mai (all 5 nights)
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Outfit: Summer outfit — but carry a scarf/shawl for the temples

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
09.50	KUL → CNX — Malaysia Airlines MH772 KLIA	2h 40m	Lands 11.40. MH792 (11.50→13.40) and AirAsia AK856 (13.30→15.10) are the other same-day options. Thailand is 1 hour behind Malaysia .
~12.30	Check in — Old City or Nimman Chiang Mai	1h	One hotel for the whole trip. Old City = temples on your doorstep; Nimman = cafés and a younger feel. Both fine.
~14.00	Wat Phra Singh + Wat Chedi Luang Old City, inside the moat Open in Google Maps	2h	The two big ones, 10 minutes apart on foot. Shoulders and knees covered — this applies to both of you at every temple.
~15 min by Grab			
~16.30	Nimmanhaemin — One Nimman + a café Nimmanhaemin Road Open in Google Maps	2h	Chiang Mai's café district: Ristr8to, Graph, Akha Ama. This is the Braga-and-Kopi-Toko-Djawa slot.
~19.00	Dinner — khao soi, then the Night Bazaar Chang Klan Road	2h	Khao soi is the northern dish to try first. Night Bazaar is touristy but good for a first evening.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Easy first day on purpose — one flight, no long transfer, unlike the Bandung and Hanoi versions.
- Grab and Bolt both work here. Songthaews (red trucks) are ~30–40 THB a hop in the city — flag one down and say where.
- Green season: showers tend to come late afternoon or overnight. Keep a light rain shell in the day bag.

DAY 2

Doi Inthanon — the roof of Thailand

Tuesday, 8 September

START 07.30	FINISH ~18.30	SLEEP Chiang Mai
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Outfit: Emerald denim casual — green terraces, cool mountain air

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
07.30	Depart with your booked car + driver	—	Book a private day tour the night before — hotel desk, Klook or GetYourGuide. This replaces Kiki for the day.
DRIVE: Chiang Mai → Doi Inthanon National Park — ~2 hours			
~09.30	Twin Royal Pagodas + gardens Doi Inthanon, 2,565 m Open in Google Maps	1.5h	The King and Queen pagodas with terraced gardens between them. Cold and windy up here — 15–20°C, bring the jacket you packed for Kawah Putih.
~11.15	Ang Ka nature trail + summit point Doi Inthanon summit Open in Google Maps	45 min	Short boardwalk through mossy cloud forest. Thailand's highest point is a marker, not a view — the trail is the good part.
~30 min down the mountain			
~12.30	Ban Mae Klang Luang — rice terraces + Karen coffee village Doi Inthanon foothills Open in Google Maps	2.5h	Vivid green terraces in September, hill-tribe village, coffee grown on the slope. Lunch here at a terrace restaurant.
~20 min			
~15.30	Wachirathan Waterfall Doi Inthanon National Park Open in Google Maps	1h	Thunderous in green season and throws spray a long way — this is the wettest you'll get all trip, which is the fun of it.
DRIVE: back to Chiang Mai — ~2 hours			
~18.30	Back in the city — dinner nearby	—	Long day. Keep dinner close to the hotel.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Longest driving day of the trip, ~4 hours total — this is the Ciwidey day of the Thailand plan.
- National park entry is charged per person at the gate; your driver will stop for it.
- Winding mountain road — the motion-sickness tablets from your checklist earn their place today.

DAY 3

Mae Rim valley — gardens, cafés, sticky waterfall

Wednesday, 9 September

START
09.00FINISH
~19.30SLEEP
Chiang Mai**Outfit:** Cream elegant — botanic gardens and forest cafés

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
09.00	Depart north into the Mae Sa valley	—	Grab works for this, but a half-day car is easier with several stops.
~40 min			
~09.45	Queen Sirikit Botanic Garden Mae Rim district Open in Google Maps	2.5h	Glasshouses, orchids and a canopy walkway through the treetops. The elegant-outfit location of the trip.
~30 min			
~13.00	Lunch at a valley café Mae Rim / Mae Sa valley	1.5h	The Giant (a treehouse café) or Fern Forest. Chiang Mai's answer to Lawangwangi and Congo.
~40 min north			
~15.30	Bua Tong Sticky Waterfalls Si Lanna National Park, Mae Taeng Open in Google Maps	2h	Limestone falls you can genuinely walk <i>up</i> — the rock grips your feet. Free entry. Bring a change of clothes: this is the Cibuni of this trip, minus the mud.
~1 hour back to the city			
~18.30	Dinner in Nimman Nimmanhaemin	1.5h	

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Mon Jam's famous flower fields are a cool-season thing (Nov-Feb). In September the valley is green and misty instead — beautiful, but manage expectations.
- Sticky Waterfalls: sandals or shoes you don't mind soaking, and the towel from the packing list.
- This is the easy-driving day: everything is within 40 minutes of the city.

Thailand · Haris Haikal & Aina Izzaty · DAY 3 · times are estimates, shuffle freely

DAY 4

Chiang Rai — White, Blue and Black

Thursday, 10 September

START
07.30 sharp

FINISH
~20.30

SLEEP
Chiang Mai

Outfit: Cute pink & white — the temples are the colour palette

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
07.30	Depart on the Chiang Rai day tour	—	A ~13-hour day. Book a small-group or private tour; it runs to a fixed timetable.
DRIVE: Chiang Mai → Chiang Rai — ~3 hours each way			
~10.30	Wat Rong Khun — the White Temple Chiang Rai Open in Google Maps	1.5h	All white and mirrored glass. The most photographed building in northern Thailand — go straight to the bridge before the coaches arrive.
~12.15	Lunch in Chiang Rai Chiang Rai town	1h	
~13.30	Wat Rong Suea Ten — the Blue Temple Chiang Rai Open in Google Maps	1h	Electric blue and gold inside. Pink and white against that blue is the photo of the day.
~15.00	Baan Dam — the Black House Nang Lae, Chiang Rai Open in Google Maps	1.5h	The dark counterpoint to the White Temple: an artist's compound of black timber halls. Odd and memorable.
DRIVE: back to Chiang Mai — ~3 hours			
~20.30	Back at the hotel	—	Late finish. Keep tomorrow gentle.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- The one genuinely long day — 6 hours in the car for three of the north's signature sights. Worth it, but do not add anything else to today.
- Snacks and water in the day bag; stops are at the tour's discretion.
- If the forecast is heavy all day, swap this with Day 5 — the temples are better in dry light.

DAY 5

Doi Suthep + city, markets and massage

Friday, 11 September

START
08.30

FINISH
~21.00

SLEEP
Chiang Mai

Outfit: Smart casual — temple-appropriate again

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
08.30	Wat Phra That Doi Suthep Doi Suthep, 30 min from the Old City Open in Google Maps	2h	Chiang Mai's landmark temple on the mountain. Go early — the cloud rolls in later and the crowds arrive with it. 300 steps up, or the funicular.
~30 min back down			
~11.30	Lunch + coffee in the Old City Old City	1.5h	
~13.30	Warorot Market Wichayanon Road, by the river Open in Google Maps	1.5h	Where locals shop: dried fruit, northern sausage, textiles, chilli pastes. This is the Kartika Sari slot — souvenirs and edible gifts.
~10 min			
~15.30	Wua Lai silver street + handicrafts Wua Lai Road, south of the moat Open in Google Maps	1.5h	Silverwork, lacquer, Lanna crafts. Sunday walking street runs here — you'll miss it, but the shops are open daily.
~17.30	Thai massage Old City	1.5h	Two hours of Thai or oil massage costs less than a taxi ride home. Book a slot mid-afternoon.
~19.30	Farewell dinner Old City or riverside Open in Google Maps	1.5h	Riverside restaurants on the Ping are the nicer end. Pack tonight.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Everything today is 10–30 minutes apart by Grab. No tour needed.
- Doi Suthep is an active temple — the strictest dress code of the trip. Cover shoulders and knees, shoes off inside.
- Leave room in the bags: Warorot and Wua Lai are where the souvenirs actually happen.

DAY 6

Fly home

Saturday, 12 September

START

Depends on flight

FINISH

KUL

SLEEP

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Outfit: Comfy travel outfit

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
08.00	Breakfast + last café Chiang Mai	1.5h	The airport is only 15–20 minutes from anywhere in the city, so there's no rush.
~10.30	Checkout → Chiang Mai Airport (CNX) ~20 min by Grab	—	Small, easy airport — international departures are straightforward.
~11.30	Check-in + immigration CNX Open in Google Maps	2h buffer	Standard 2 hours for an international flight.
afternoon	CNX → KUL	~2h 40m	Confirm your return time when you book the outbound — Malaysia is 1 hour ahead.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- CNX is the easiest airport exit of any version of this trip — 20 minutes from the hotel.